Calibrating the abstention threshold

Two automated runs, each compared against its own verified assessment. The design record names the abstention threshold as the highest-leverage parameter in the system — too loose and everything reads Ready, too tight and everything reads Unverified — and says it must be tuned against both countries before any new country runs. This is that comparison.

The two runs side by side

	Egypt	Nigeria
rows at the verified level (of 57)	29	33
prerequisites matching (of 12)	8	8
recorded gaps	14 (verified: 5)	17 (verified: 4)
ratification holds	10 (verified: 5)	8 (verified: 7)
levels withheld where the verified assessment set one	15	15
rows read HIGHER than the verified assessment	**3**	**5**
cost	$6.62	$7.58

The row to read is the last but one. The pipeline's error is overwhelmingly in the direction of saying too little, not too much — which is the failure the design record chose when it made abstention a first-class answer.

Is the abstention the pipeline, or the country?

6 rows withheld a level in BOTH countries. Those are the pipeline. Rows withheld in only one are that country's data environment.

	rows	which
withheld in both	6	1.6, 1.7, 2.7, 5.8, 6.14, 8.4
Egypt only	9	1.5, 3.3, 3.5, 3.7, 4.4, 6.4, 6.12, 8.9, 8.11
Nigeria only	9	1.1, 2.1, 2.11, 3.4, 4.2, 4.3, 4.7, 6.9, 8.6

The split that decides which lever to pull

Of the rows withheld in both countries, the ones the pipeline **never reached** need more retrieval, and no threshold change will rescue them. The ones it reached and **declined to level** are the threshold.

	rows
not reached in both	4
declined in both	2

67% of the rows both countries withheld were never reached at all. On this evidence the binding constraint is retrieval, not the abstention threshold — which is what the vendor audition also found, where every entrant abstained on the same four known-answer cells because the page carrying the answer was behind a JavaScript dashboard or inside a survey PDF. Loosening the threshold would not have produced those levels; it would only have produced levels with less behind them.

Why each country declined, gate by gate

country	declined: coherence	declined: construct	declined: tier	not reached
Egypt	0	6	3	6
Nigeria	1	4	1	9

Every row read higher than its verified assessment

The dangerous direction, in full, for both countries.

- **Egypt 2.11 Device financing/subsidy schemes** — verified L1, recorded L3. Egypt’s Ministry of Communications and Information Technology operates ProGIG, a joint initiative of the National Telecommunication Institute and Nasser Social Bank offering soft loans of up to EGP 65,000 (with a 50% dis
- **Egypt 3.8 National soil map/database** — verified L1, recorded L3. The indicator names a ‘National soil map/database’. The best available evidence describes (a) national digital soil and terrain data of Egypt produced by NARSS with FAO/European Soil Bureau, and (b) EALIP’s GIS-based nat
- **Egypt 7.12 Responsible-AI safeguards (consent, rights)** — verified L1, recorded L3. Egypt adopted a cross-sector Egyptian Charter for Responsible AI, launched by the National Council for Artificial Intelligence in April 2023, built on five values (Human-Centeredness, Transparency and Explainability, Fai
- **Nigeria 4.9 Inter-ministerial coordination mechanism** — verified L1, recorded L3. The Vice President, Senator Kashim Shettima, has inaugurated the Interministerial Committee on Research and Innovation with a charge to its members to ensure food security in Nigeria, energy security to power the economy
- **Nigeria 6.4 Agtech venture ecosystem** — verified L3, recorded L4. Nigeria has an operating agritech venture ecosystem of digital solution providers for smallholder

farmers, supported by incubators, accelerators, angel investors and donors, but only a handful of start-ups have scaled.

- **Nigeria 6.12 Digital public goods adopted** — verified L1, recorded L2. The indicator name (“Digital public goods adopted”) is ambiguous per the census note. The best available evidence sits on the POLICY-ADOPTION side of that question: Nigeria joining the DPGA and committing, via its DPI Fr
- **Nigeria 7.2 AI-enabled agricultural solutions deployed** — verified L2, recorded L3. FAO’s Science, Technology and Innovation Portal records the AKILIMO Nigeria Integrated Digital Agronomic Solution — classified as an artificial intelligence (AI) digital technology — as adopted in Nigeria at the ’Livelih
- **Nigeria 8.12 Documented impact evidence (yield/income)** — verified L3, recorded L4. A randomized controlled trial of the RiceAdvice digital personalized-extension app in Nigeria found that farm households receiving personalized advice increased their yield by 7% and their profit by 10%.

The cheapest coverage there is

Every run fetches a machine-readable T1 lane separately and reports it beside the research lane’s own answer without ever substituting it — a measurement run that quietly swapped in an API figure would be measuring the API. The rows below are ones where the research lane recorded a gap while that independent T1 series had the figure all along. Each one is already visible on its row, which said so in its note; each is also a level available for the price of a decision.

country	id	indicator	the T1 series had
Egypt	5.3	Tertiary STEM enrollment (% gross)	38.04 (2025) — World Bank WDI SE.TER.ENRR
Nigeria	1.1	Agriculture value added per worker	3494.89 (2025) — World Bank WDI NV.AGR.EMPL.KD
Nigeria	5.3	Tertiary STEM enrollment (% gross)	9.74 (2011) — World Bank WDI SE.TER.ENRR

3 rows across both countries. Whether the T1 lane should be allowed to fill a gap the research lane could not is a real design question and not one to settle silently: it trades a measurement of what the research lane can do for coverage a reader would rather have. It is recorded here as an open decision.

Rows to fix by hand before the next country

Withheld in both countries and never reached: these are named sources behind interfaces the Exa/Jina substrate does not open. Each is a targeted retrieval job, not a tuning question, and fixing one fixes it for every country.

- **1.6 Smallholder access to formal markets (%)**

- **1.7 Agricultural credit access (% farmers)**
- **2.7 Rural smartphone ownership (%)**
- **8.4 Mobile money account (%)**

What the second review changed, in both countries

outcome	Egypt	Nigeria
filled	4	4
withdrawn	0	0
relevelled	0	1
adjusted	3	3
upheld	29	28
cost	$6.35	$5.99